Bhagat Singh was not ‘only one of India’s greatest freedom fighters and revolutionary socialists, but also one of its early Marxist thinkers and ideologues’.[6] This explains why, as Christopher Pinney has noted, in the period up to Independence in 1947, ‘images of Bhagat Singh were more prevalent than those of Mahatma Gandhi, in both contemporary India and in chromolithographs of the pre-independence era’. Small wonder then that he describes this as ‘a stunning anomaly, given the dominance of the Mahatma in narratives of the nationalist movement’.[7] Ironically, however, the predominant narrative today is that it is Gandhian non-violence that secured India’s Independence. The young revolutionaries are at best marginalized and at worst forgotten. It remains a paradox how the non-violent creed paved the way to the violence of Partition, something to which the revolutionaries would never have agreed, with a million dead and fifteen million uprooted from their homes. Yet, the ‘violence’ of the revolutionaries is derided and disparaged. The real violence of how India came to gain its freedom is bizarrely accepted as an inevitable part of the story of how the country achieved its freedom.

This is why an Indian scholar recently felt it necessary to declare that ‘Even though India did not have a revolution, it has a large number of revolutionaries.’[8] R.C. Majumdar is described by Durba Ghosh as ‘perhaps the most eminent Bengali historian to claim, against an official nationalist consensus, that Bengal’s history of militant nationalism had been central to forging the necessary politics for an anti-colonial movement’.[9] In the foreword to Uma Mukherjee’s *Two Great Indian Revolutionaries: Rash Behari and Jyotindra Nath Banerjee*, he has explained how, ‘[i]n spite of the attempts in some quarters to minimize the role of the revolutionaries in the history of the freedom movement in India, their countrymen are now becoming gradually conscious of the deep debt of gratitude they owe to these heroes for the achievement of Indian independence’.[10] Indeed, as Aparna Vaidik has more recently pointed out, even ‘the role of the anti-hero’ such as ‘Hans Raj Vohra (1909–1985), who testified against his *HSRA* comrades in the Lahore Conspiracy Case’ needs to be understood in the context of ‘a non-celebratory history of nationalism, which is sensitive to